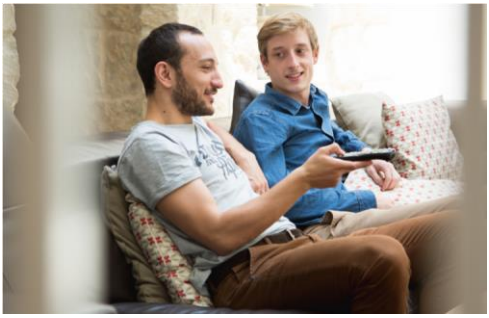

Homestay Manual *EC Boston*

www.ecenglish.com

Hosting international students offers you the exciting and rewarding experience of inviting new cultures into your home and into your life!

The homestay experience gives you the opportunity to share your Boston customs and daily life with a foreign student in a familiar home atmosphere. By no means is hosting an easy job. This is why we look for dedicated and patient individuals who recognize the gratification and wisdom that each challenge can bring.

Students choose homestay from a number of accommodation options to have a first-hand view of American culture and immerse themselves with native English speakers. This is often the first time away from home for many of our students.

They are looking for a home environment where they can practice their English language skills and interact with American people in a natural environment.
Each student, like each homestay, is unique. Along with the many rewards, there can be some challenges. This guide outlines the policies of the EC Homestay Programme and will help you create a consistent and enjoyable homestay experience for your family and your students. As well as outlining the EC standards for homestay, we offer you tips and advice on making the most of your homestay experience.

Please read through this manual carefully. If you need clarification or have any questions, please speak with your Accommodation personnel.

What makes a good Host?

You have been selected from many potential hosts because you have impressed us by showing an interest in other cultures, a willingness to share your home and American culture with a foreign student and your motivation for hosting has not been purely financial.

Financial motivation will lead to disappointment. Hosting students is not a reliable source of income and should not be depended upon to pay your mortgage, your rent or your bills. Many factors go into placing a student in a homestay (personal preferences, distance from the school, student evaluations and seasonal fluctuations in student enrolments). Likewise, many circumstances can influence a booking even after it has been confirmed (visa denials, last minute registration cancellations, or students deciding to leave a homestay).

Students can sense when homestays are hosting for financial reasons and this will lead to a disappointing experience for you and for our students.

A good host is someone who has time, on a regular basis, to dedicate to the Homestay Programme.

Students choosing homestay are looking for contact with American people and want to interact with their hosts. Invite your students to chat in the evening and to join in family activities; this will go a long way towards making your students feel ‘at home’.

Lack of contact is the most common cause of dissatisfaction in the Homestay Program.

It is amazing to see the long-term relationships that are built through the Homestay Programme. EC's hosts are known worldwide for the hospitality and service they provide. Students that have had a great learning experience here in Boston go back to their country and recommend not only EC to their friends and colleagues, but they also recommend their homestay hosts! Students remain in contact with their host families, return to study or visit – and have even invited their hosts to their country as well! Returning students request and recommend the hosts who welcomed them, provided them with a home-away-from-home experience and enhanced their learning through conversation and guidance.

Homestay is one of the most important services offered at EC – it is equally as important as the academic programme. If a student is unhappy with their homestay, they will not be happy at school regardless of how good our school is. EC relies on you and your family to provide our students with a homestay experience that is up to EC standards.

The EC Homestay Host is someone who…

- Spends enough time with students to help them feel at home
- Provides new students with information about the home routine and the neighbourhood
- Shows new students how to get to EC on their first day of school

- Provides varied, balanced meals and takes the time to find out what the student likes to eat
- Is consistent with students about maintaining house rules and EC policies
- Supports EC standards and policies
- Understands the low/high season cycle in our enrolment and the limitations of this cycle
- Enjoys learning about other countries and cultures
- Provides a supportive foundation for our students to learn English, discover Boston, make friends and create life-long memories

Homestay Holidays

When students choose homestay as their accommodation they expect to spend plenty of time with you so that they can learn about American culture. However, we understand that you might have a family trip or holiday while you host a student. If your holiday is already planned, please let your accommodation personnel know so that we will not place a student with you during this time. In the case of an emergency, please contact your accommodation personnel to make alternative arrangements.

Changing Homestays

Since you must accept students prior to meeting them, EC Boston undertake to move those with whom you are dissatisfied. If your student requests a change, EC Boston will advise you why the student is not satisfied and if a change will take place. Movement of homestay can happen at any time depending on the urgency of the situation, but EC Boston will try to move on the following Saturday.

Extending Students

When students extend their accommodation in homestay, this is usually because the service being provided is excellent. However, if you accept a student in advance from EC, the extending student will generally be moved to a different homestay. This is because the advance placement you accepted for a future student has priority over an extension requested by your current student. We ask for your assistance in respecting this procedure.

When students decide to extend their stay in homestay, they must continue to pay fees directly to the school. If a student decides to stop their studies at EC and would like to stay with you, please check with EC Boston. We ask you not to collect any money directly from the student.

Homestays who collect fees directly from students referred by EC will lose access to future placements from EC.

However, in the case of students staying outside of the dates we have informed you, please inform your accommodation personnel immediately so that we may arrange it with the students. Extra nights will be included in your next payment only if we have collected them in the office**. Again, we ask you not to collect any money directly from the student.**

Upkeep of EC's Policies

Upkeep of EC's Policies EC has written policies and standards to uphold. It is imperative that our homestay hosts see the importance of these policies and standards. Failure to

respect the following EC standards and policies will result in being terminated as a homestay host.

- Not following the One Language Policy
- Harassment of student – verbal, emotional, sexual, physical etc.
- Use of illegal substances or severe intoxication of alcohol
- Theft of student property
- Taking payments from students privately
- Unkempt / unhygienic house
- Unhealthy or inadequate meals being served consistently
- Severe personality conflicts or cultural conflict

Homestay Requirements

Arrival and Departure

Most students arrive on the Saturday/Sunday preceding the start date of their course and depart on the Saturday/Sunday immediately after the last day of their course. Sometimes students arrive in Boston before the weekend. In this case, we will ask you if it is possible to accept the student earlier. If it is inconvenient to accept early arrivals (or late departures), with only a moment's notice, the student will generally be directed to a hotel or residence. However, if a request for extra nights is made well in advance or is part of an original booking request and you are unable to accommodate the student, he or she will be placed with another homestay family.

Most often, arrival times are available only two or three days in advance. We make every effort to secure all arrival times, but some are still not reported to us. Sometimes students contact you directly to tell you their arrival time. If this happens, please advise your Accommodation Personnel.

If you receive no arrival time, please do not wait at home the entire weekend for your student. You should come and go as you please during the designated arrival weekend, checking periodically for messages from the student. Please do not leave town during the arrival weekend.

Being home to greet the student is crucial to ensuring that your relationship with the student begins on a positive note. As the old saying goes "First impressions are lasting impressions". If we have provided you with the arrival information, **it is your responsibility to be at home to receive your student**. It is not unusual to wait more than two hours between the time the flight lands and the time the student arrives at your home. Students on an international flight must collect their baggage, go through customs, and may need to go through immigration. If you are not at home when the student arrives, the tired student feels unwelcome and the relationship begins on a bad note.

Not only should you be at home to greet the student, but you should also plan to spend extra time with your student upon arrival. Make sure you are not too absorbed in doing something else when the student arrives. For example, it is improper to be entertaining guests, or baby-sitting your neighbours' children when the student arrives, as it may appear that the student's arrival is unimportant and insignificant. It is almost impossible to reverse the effects of a bad impression. It often results in the student wanting to move out of your home immediately. If the student arrives very late at night, please welcome them as above and spend the extra time with them the next morning.

Homestay hosts **do not** provide airport reception for students. Should a student call you to give you their arrival time or to request that you pick them up at the airport, please tell the student to contact the school directly. Then call the Emergency Phone (617-990-4880) immediately so that we can make the appropriate arrangements for their safe arrival. **Should a student call outside of school hours asking to be picked up, please advise the student to take a taxi to your house.**

Students can select our optional airport transfer service if they want to be met at the airport upon arrival. They are met at the airport by the uniformed taxi driver. If a student that has requested an arrival pick up calls you on the arrival weekend about changed arrival plans, be sure to write down the new arrival date, time and flight number. Students who did not request airport pick up will make their own way to your home. Please note that the EC transfer is a one-way service. We do not take the student to the airport on departure unless this service is additionally requested. We require students to vacate their bedroom by 11:00 A.M. on departure day. Students catching a later flight should feel welcome to stay in your home and to store baggage with you until they are ready to leave. Please be at home to say goodbye.

Arrival Weekends

First impressions are lasting impressions! To ensure that your relationship with the student begins on a positive note, it is your responsibility to be at home to receive your student when they arrive.

EC's Guide to Welcoming Your Students

We are constantly looking to improve the overall experience for our students and as the students' first point of contact we need your support in giving them the best possible welcome. We want to make them feel at home when they arrive on their first day so we've put these guidelines together for you which we'd like you to follow to ensure they have a great start to their stay in Boston.

- **Students have told us that whilst they are extremely excited about their stay, they also tend to be quite nervous. To avoid any further stress and anxiety please be home to greet your student at the agreed time! This will ensure that your relationship with the student begins on a positive note.**

- **Most students will be tired after their journey so it would be nice if you could help them take their luggage to their room. Please also give them the EC Welcome Letter, Student Homestay Manual and map which we have provided.**

- Students have told us that one of the most memorable things about a homestay is a genuinely personal welcome. This doesn't necessarily need to cost anything, but we ask that you think about what you could do to make them feel really welcome in your home. For example:
    - A little 'welcome to our home' picture drawn by your child.
    - A freshly brewed cup of tea or coffee with a biscuit.
    - If you like baking, perhaps some fresh cake or some muffins?
    - A hand-written note with your personal top 3 favourite things to do in Boston
    - If you have a garden, perhaps a fresh bunch of flowers from your garden in the student's room.
    - …or anything else that you feel represents you and your family!

Students will remember your kind gesture and it will start the whole experience in your home on the right note.

- Give them a tour of your house so that they know where to find everything.
- Introduce them to key members of the household.
- Go through any rules with them to help manage the student's expectations and make you and them feel comfortable right from the start.
- Please give students a tour of the area so that they know where the nearest T station/bus stop/local amenities/parks etc. are. This is really important as students have fed back to us that they are most anxious about how to get to school on the first day. Please explain to them how to get to school step by step, or if you have the time, travel to school with them during the weekend so that they will have done the journey once before.

Please have dinner with them in the evening. This will make the students feel included and part of your home straight away. And of course, if a student arrives very late in the evening, some of these guidelines will need to be carried out the next day once the student is well rested after a good night's sleep.

Interaction with Students

All members of the household must speak fluent English. EC hosts must ensure that they (and/or other members of the household) have time, on a regular basis, to interact with students. Students have not chosen homestay for lodging and food only. They want to practice their new language through conversation, hear colloquial English and spend time with you as well!

One Language, One Home

EC guarantees that speakers of the same language will not be placed in the same homestay, unless the student specifically requests this. We appreciate that homestays may work with other homestay services. However, **you must tell your Accomodation Personnel the language background and gender of all students in your homestay so that we may place a student of a different language with you**. This is very important. Finding more than one student of the same language group in the same home will be sufficient grounds for EC to move our student from your homestay immediately. It also jeopardizes your working relationship with EC.

Distance from the School

Students are guaranteed that their homestay will be a maximum of one hour's travelling time to the school on public transport. We rarely accept hosts who live more than 60 minutes by public transport from the school.

Room

Hosts must provide each student with a separate room and a key to the house. Twin room option: 2 students share a bedroom. The twin room is equipped either with a double/ queen/king bed (nonstandard twin room) or 2 separate single or double beds (the standard twin room). All rooms must include a bed, closet, desk, and a lamp for studying. Most importantly all rooms must have a window. Please show your students where extra blankets or a portable heater is kept in case they are cold.

Private Bath Homestay

Private bath homestay guarantees the student the sole use of a private bathroom within the homestay. A private bath homestay bathroom must be equipped with a sink, a toilet and either a shower or a bathtub and may not be used by any other members of the household (including other students). It is not necessary that the bathroom is ensuite to the student's room and it is the responsibility of the homestay host to clean the bathroom once per week. Students pay a supplementary cost to benefit from the private bath homestay service.

If you have two bathrooms and are able to host two students, please ensure that the student who is paying the private bath homestay supplement has sole use of one of the bathrooms. The student who has not chosen the private bath homestay supplement must use the family bathroom.

Meals

Hosts serve two meals daily: breakfast and dinner or breakfast only if the student has chosen the BB option. Students supply their own lunch and snacks. Please provide the students with fridge and cupboard space to store their snacks and lunch foods. Please do not provide your student with lunches. Although you may feel that this is a kind and generous gesture, it actually harms other homestays that are following EC guidelines. Invite your students to go grocery shopping with you. This can be a great learning experience as you will find out the student's tastes and spend quality time together. Please ensure that meals include the four basic food groups: protein (meat, fish, egg, beans); carbohydrates (bread, pasta, rice); dairy products (milk, cheese, yoghurt); fruit and vegetables.

Hosts and students should work out suitable mealtimes together. It is acceptable to have your students prepare their own breakfast, but you must be home for dinner on a regular basis for a sit down dinner. Please inform your students what time to call you if they will be late or not come home for dinner. If students advise you that they will be late for a

meal, please leave out food that can be warmed up when they arrive home. Should you be obliged to miss dinner, please prepare a dish that your student can easily warm up.

Laundry

Hosts must provide and wash students' towels and sheets once weekly. Students are responsible for their personal laundry, and laundry supplies (detergent, fabric softener etc) should be provided by the host. All homestays are required to give students access to the laundry facilities in the home at least once and preferably twice a week. Please show your students how to use your washer and dryer, or if you prefer, you can include the students' laundry with your own. However, some students prefer to wash their own laundry, particularly intimate apparel. Hosts with laundry facilities located in their apartment/condo building are responsible for supplying the student with the required coins/tokens for one wash and dry per week.

Internet Access

Internet access should be offered to the student upon arrival in your home. The payment that you receive for hosting the student includes the internet usage. However, students should be aware that extensive download and streaming may cause you to incur supplementary charges on your internet bill and they should refrain from this. Therefore, you need to have an internet connection in your house every time you are hosting a student for EC Boston.

Long-distance Telephone Calls

Students are able to receive long-distance calls until 10:00 p.m. Boston time. They are not able to make outgoing calls unless they have your permission and the call is collect or made with a prepaid calling card. Calling cards are available for sale at most convenience stores near the school. We advise you to permit no exceptions to this rule. The school does not accept responsibility for any charges on your phone bill.

First Day at School for New Students

We ask that new students arrive at EC no later than 8:30 for first day procedures. You are required to show them how to use the public transport system and how to travel to school. Please show your students how to get to school on the weekend prior to first day, bearing in mind that timing will be different than during busy weekday commutes.

It is also important that you provide students with the following information:

- Your address and telephone number
- The closest main road to your home
- The number of the bus or train and any transfers they must take
- The corner of the bus stop (if needed)

Please provide directions for the return trip as sometimes there are slight differences in the route and/or bus numbers. Remember to inform your accommodation personnel if your transport route changes so we can update your profile.

EC Activities

EC employs full-time Coordinators of Student Activities who plan activities in the evenings and on weekends. Participation in activities by students is optional. Some students go to almost every activity, while others prefer to stay at home.

EC posts upcoming Activity Calendars on our website. You can also find the Activities Calendar on our Facebook page. Please refer to this calendar for information about scheduled events. Don't forget to like us on facebook!!

Even though EC plans special outings for your students, please remember to include them in your daily activities. Going shopping? Going away for the weekend? Going for a walk? Watching TV? Why not ask the students to join you? Many students need to be invited to join you, as they may be too shy to ask to participate in household activities. Students should be made to feel like one of the family.

Evaluations

Feedback from our students is the most important method of helping us provide the best quality homestay possible. Like any other service industry, our success is measured by our ability to respond to our clients' needs. All students receive questionnaires to evaluate the service you provide. One is given at the start of their stay and a final questionnaire is given to them on their last day of classes.

Please do not answer questions that you are not sure of or give any information that is in conflict with the school's interests. If students express concern about their teachers, fees, or anything else, they should be directed to the office. In fact, please refer your students to the office with any questions they may have regarding immigration policies, health insurance or any other matter. We are here to help them in any way possible. At EC, we strive to ensure students are happy with all our service areas.

Rules for Students

Responsibility for Students' Behaviour

You are not legally responsible for the behaviour of students. You are responsible for giving your student an understandable explanation of the rules of your home.

The school has four basic rules for students' behaviour in the home: no long-distance calls made without a pre-paid phone card, no overnight guests without your permission, calling to advise if they will be missing dinner or staying out all night and no untidiness. We encourage you to supplement these with your own house rules. Please take the time to explain all house rules with each new student you host – what might seem obvious to you, may not be apparent for your student.

Please encourage your student to read the EC Student Handbook, which they are given during registration on first day.

Guests

Students are advised that they cannot have overnight guests in their room. The school keeps records of inexpensive alternate accommodation options. We will assist students in accommodating friends and relatives. Please refer them to the school if the question arises.

Chores

Students should make their beds, tidy their rooms, and clean up after snacks. Please do not ask them to do any other housework, outdoor work, dog walking or baby-sitting.

Induction to Household Routines

Please induct your students to your household routines and explain how to operate all appliances. *The school does not accept any responsibility for any damage incurred by the students.*

Health Insurance

Students can independently purchase health insurance from private insurance companies from their home country.

Please note that the school keeps a list of doctors and dentists.

Concerns

Cultural Differences and Communication

Developing awareness of cultural differences constitutes one of the most rewarding aspects of hosting international students. These differences sometimes pose a challenge to effective and easy communication. Something that appears simple and a matter of common sense to you may appear complex or strange to your students.

Students arriving from abroad have many adjustments to make. Some of the biggest differences they face include: food, social customs, schedules, and of course, language. Knowledge is the best tool to use when helping your student through this transition period.

In order to enhance the opportunity for pleasant relations between you and your students, we recommend that you make a special effort to understand your students' cultural backgrounds and be sensitive to their differences.
We also recommend that you take the time and care to explain our cultural norms and your special homestay rules.

Culture Shock, There are typically 4 stages of culture shock. Each student will spend different amounts of time in each stage:

Honeymoon: Differences are intriguing and the student feels excited and curious.

Shock: The differences begin to create an impact. The student may feel confused, inadequate or isolated. Frustration and anger can also be a result of culture shock. The student may wish to reject the differences he/she is experiencing.

Negotiation: The student learns to deal with the problems of cultural difference. Differences are integrated with their own beliefs and similarities are identified.

Acceptance: The student is able to live well in the environment with the differences they are experiencing.

Symptoms of culture shock can include: irritability, withdrawal from people who are different, extreme homesickness, overeating or loss of appetite, boredom, a need for excessive sleep, headaches, upset stomach, and inexplicable crying. Your student may experience a number or none of these symptoms.

When dealing with a student in culture shock it is important to be patient and understanding. You are the people the student will look to for support while in Boston!

Some Solutions for Culture Shock

Some of the ways you can help ease the student's stress are:

Keep them Active: By getting the student out of their room, they are able to experience the new culture first-hand. This will help them watch and learn how British customs are practiced.

Talk!: Talk to your students about your family and American customs. Answer their questions. This will help them feel more comfortable with you and with the cultural differences.

Keep in touch: Encourage your student to write letters or call their family regularly. Talking to someone familiar can make the student feel better, and may encourage them when they're feeling homesick.

Exercise: Help your student to find an enjoyable activity. This will enable them to reduce stress and depression.

Accommodation Personnel

If you encounter difficulties with your students despite your best efforts, please contact Katie Godfrey. One of the most important responsibilities is to act as liaison between students and hosts; most common concerns can be resolved quickly if there is open communication. EC will counsel students about any aspect of adapting to life in Boston including immigration or legal matters, health and health insurance, emotional or personal problems, or financial concerns.

Please be understanding and receptive when EC Boston contacts you to discuss a concern. Remember we are trying to help, whether it is to clarify a miscommunication concern, or dissatisfaction on the part of the client. Our job is to inquire and find acceptable solutions.

Please know that the student can request to leave your home at any time. EC has a responsibility to its clients and its homestay hosts. If a client does not feel comfortable with the homestay family where he or she has been placed, EC will find them another homestay. EC will show the homestay hosts the same consideration. If a homestay host does not feel comfortable with the student, we will find a new family for the student immediately.

Helpful Hints and Guidelines

Do be home to greet the student when we have provided you with the arrival information. Remember first impressions are lasting impressions!

Do remember that even though it is not your first time hosting, it is almost always the first time your student is being hosted. Every new student is just that, NEW! New to Boston, new to your home, new to the school. It is important to treat every student like your first.

To help your student feel more welcomed, wait to explain your house rules. Wait at least one full day until the jet lag has worn off. This will help comprehension.

Do take an interest in your students; get to know them personally. It is of the utmost importance that you have enough time to dedicate to the students. Hosts should take an interest in finding out whom the students are as individuals, where they come from, about their country and customs, and the student's views on current events. You should initiate conversations. Do not wait for the students to talk to you. Take the time to talk to them.

Do provide specific bus/T information for every one of your students with directions on how to get to and from your home to EC, bearing in mind that school starts at 8:00 a.m. on the first day and 8:30 a.m. thereafter. It is also important to many students to know the schedule of the last bus/T to your home. Students rely on the public transportation and appreciate your assistance in making the information clear to them.

Do avoid any and all monetary transactions with the student.

Do remember that EC guarantees our clients a maximum of 4 students per household during the same time period. We really want the student to feel that he/she has been placed in a family environment and not a residence or rooming house.

Try not to serve too much canned, frozen or fast food. Freshly prepared foods are healthier anyway!

Do inform your accommodation personnel if you plan to be away for more than 24 hours. Remember if you are going to be away for more than one week during the student's intended stay, do not take a student for that period. In addition, do not take a student if you are going to be away any length of time during the first two weeks after the student's arrival.

Avoid comparing your new student with old students. Repeated comments such as how many times the old students helped you, or how many gifts you received, or how sweet they were to call you on your birthday will only make the new student feel uncomfortable. The new student will feel that he or she will have to do the same things in order to please you.

Avoid making comments on the level that the student has been placed in by the school. For example, saying "My other student was in level 5 and couldn't speak as much as you do and yet you are only in level 4", is not constructive. The school evaluators have good reasons for having made their decision.

Do inform your accommodation personnel if you plan to use a room other that the one inspected.

Do remind your students of the benefits of staying in the Homestay Programme. When two or more students wish to share an apartment because they think it is more economical for them, there may be many things they did not consider in their decision. Do they really know the person with whom they are going to share the apartment? Is the area safe? Who can help them if they run into trouble? Will they still have the chance to practice their new language? If they think about all the benefits they receive from the Homestay

Programme, they will find our programme is less expensive and more effective for improving their language skills.

Do promote our activities programme by telling the students about the proposed tours. Students will appreciate your opinion on what is good to see in Boston. Participating in activities will enhance the students' cultural experience.

Do inform your accommodation personnel of any changes in your home, such as visiting relatives, new pets, if someone moves out, if you quit smoking, if you change careers, etc. We need to update your file so that incoming students get the most up-to-date information.

Do keep a special record at home of every student who has stayed with you; a photo with student's names, address, telephone number and sometimes a few lines about the student to help you remember them by. You will often hear from them after they have returned to their countries.

Do encourage students to receive all mail and packages at the school. We have a student mail pick-up. Students sometimes move and you will continue to receive their mail otherwise.

Try not to alarm your student by warning them about street safety or bad neighbourhoods. If there are communication difficulties, the student may only hear the word "danger" and ask to be moved from your home. All accommodation is inspected and we would never place a student in an unsafe environment.

Try not to take negative feedback from students personally. We understand that there are always 2 sides to every story. We will view the students' comments objectively. Please note, however, that if EC continues to receive negative evaluations regarding the homestay's services, we will re-evaluate your status at EC.

EC Programmes

EC offers a variety of different programmes:

- General English
- Intensive English
- English For Work
- One-to-one lessons
- English - Academic Semester/Year
- English - Intensive Academic Semester/Year
- Exam classes

Programme Descriptions 20 & 30 Lessons:

EC provides levels of English ranging from absolute beginner to advanced. Upon arrival at EC, students are given a placement test. Based on the results, students are placed in a level which best corresponds to their needs and abilities.

The **20 Lessons** (15 hrs per week) programme covers the 4 basic language skills: speaking, listening, reading and writing. An ESL instructor leads the students in listening comprehension, grammar, pronunciation practice, vocabulary expansion, reading, writing and composition. The 30 Lessons (22.5 hrs per week) programmes supplement the language skills of the 20 Lessons programme with a range of carefully chosen topics offered on a rotational basis for the students.

On-Time Arrival Policy

Please remind your students that they must arrive on time for lessons. Upon request of our students, EC has an **"on time arrival"** policy to reduce classroom interruptions. Teachers close the classroom doors at 9:00 sharp. Teachers will open their doors once at 9:30 to allow latecomers to join the class. If a student is late three times, it is counted as 1 full absence for that class. Attendance % is indicated on the certificate the student received at the end of the course.